

MAGICK OF THE BEAST

Crowley and the Thelemic religion

The controversial British occultist Aleister Crowley developed Thelema, his own belief system, in the early 1900s, having utterly rejected Christianity. Thelema (the Greek word for “will”) drew on many spiritual and esoteric traditions, such as Kabbalah (see pp.136–139), Rosicrucianism (see pp.154–157), and goetia (see p.142). Famous for both his debauchery and his self-indulgence, Crowley encouraged Thelemites to engage in ritual, and sometimes erotic, magick (he used the variant spelling to distinguish his magic from conjuring).

Pathway to paradise

In 1898, Crowley had joined the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (see pp.242–243). He had wanted its rites and esoteric magic to reveal a world inhabited by demonic and ethereal beings—manifestations of a universal truth—but his hopes were dashed.

The revelation Crowley sought was soon to come. In Cairo in 1904, he claimed he was visited by a Holy Guardian Angel, Aiwass, an ancient Egyptian spirit, who dictated the text that became *The Book of the Law*: the cornerstone of his new religion, Thelema. Crowley saw himself as a Thelemic prophet, whose role was to guide humanity into the Aeon of Horus (the third Aeon in the Thelemic version of history, and the one in which humanity was to take control of its own destiny).

Crowley promoted Thelema through the A.:A.: (Astrum Argenteum, or Order of the Silver Star), a group he founded as a successor to the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn. In 1910, he also became

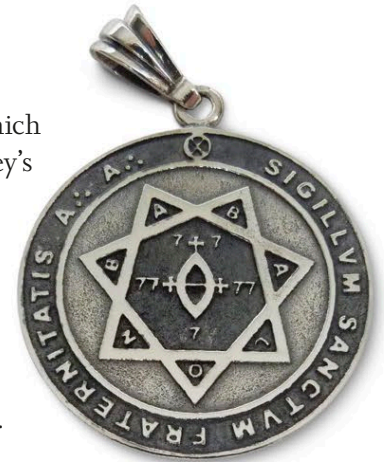
► Ritual magick

Crowley, here performing rites, knew the impact of complex ritual on magical spiritual development—the Gnostic Mass (see p.253) involved at least five ceremonially clad celebrants.

part of the Ordo Templi Orientis (see p.253), which adopted Thelema as its religion and used Crowley’s Thelemic Gnostic Mass as its central ritual.

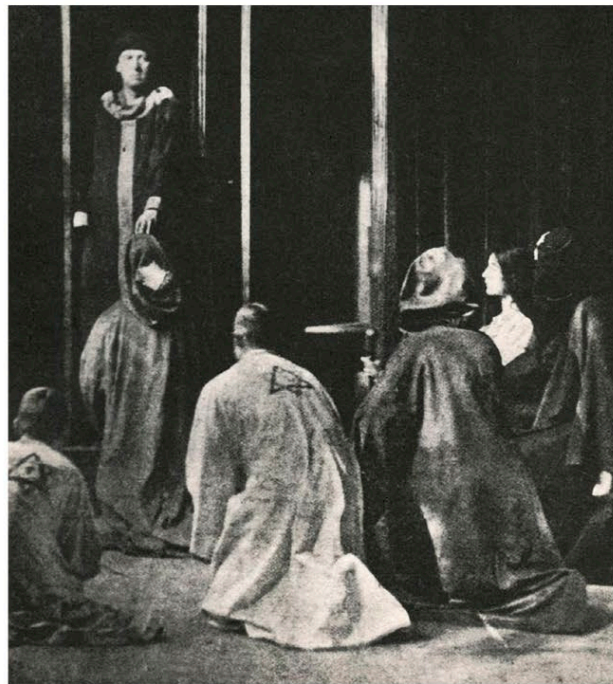
The future of Thelema

By 1920, Crowley had a headquarters—the Abbey of Thelema—in Sicily. There, he built a spiritual community focused around ritual magick, the importance of personal will, and sex. He considered sexual energy to be a source of magical power that could be used in Thelemic rituals to align participants with their true will. Crowley had long delighted in the scandal that his hypersexuality provoked in the pious Victorian world, but it led to his expulsion from Sicily in 1923. However, neither this nor his death in 1947 ended Thelema, which is still practiced today.



▲ Astrum Argenteum seal

The seven-pointed star—a seal of Crowley’s A.:A.: group—represents both masculine and feminine. The spiritual organization was founded by Crowley in 1907.



“Do what they wilt, shall be the whole law.
Love is the law, love under will.”